Poem Against the State (of Things): 1975

By June Jordan

INTRODUCTION

By the summer of 1971, the state prison in Attica, New York, was ready to explode. Inmates were frustrated with chronic overcrowding, censorship of letters, and living conditions that limited them to one shower per week and one roll of toilet paper each month. A riot ensued and hostages were taken. After four days of unsuccessful negotiations . . . On the rainy Monday morning of September 13 at 9:46 a.m., helicopters flew over the yard, dropping tear gas as state police and correction officers stormed in with guns blazing. The police fired 3,000 rounds , killing 29 inmates and 10 of the hostages. Most were shot in the initial barrage of gunfire, but other prisoners were shot or killed after they surrendered. In the week after its conclusion, police engaged in brutal reprisals against the prisoners, forcing them to run a gauntlet of nightsticks and crawl naked across broken glass, among other tortures. In 1974, lawyers representing the 1,281 inmates filed a $2.8 billion class-action lawsuit against prison and state officials.

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4NG Fanatics

wherever I go (these
days)
the tide seems low
(oh) wherever I go (these
days)
the tide seems very
very low

ATTICA!
ALLENDE!
AMERIKA!

Welcome to the Sunday School
of outfront machineguns
and secretive
assassinations

EVERYBODY WELCOME!

Put your money on the plate
your feet on the floor
and better keep a bodyguard
standing at the open door

EVERYBODY WELCOME!

Almighty
Multinational
Corporate
Incorporeal

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Bank of the World
The World Bank
Diplomacy
and Gold
This is the story:
This is the prayer:
Rain fell
Monday the thirteenth
1971
Attica
coldstone covered by a cold moon -
light hidden by the night
when fifteen hundred Black
Puerto Rican
White (one or two)
Altogether Fifteen Hundred Men
plus
thirty-eight hostages
(former keepers of the keys
to the ugliest
big
house of them all)
Fifteen Hundred and Thirty
Eight
Men

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lay sleeping in a long
wait
for the sun
and not one with a gun
not one with a gun
(oh) wherever I go
the tide seems low
Fifteen Hundred and Thirty
Eight
prisoners in prison
at Attica / they
lay sleeping in a long
long wait
for the sun
and not one with a gun
not one with a gun
But they were not really alone:
ATTICA!
ALLENDE!
Despite
the quiet of the cold moon -
light on the coldstone
of the place
Despite
the rain that fell

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transforming the D-yard
blankets and tents
into heavyweight, soggy
and sweltering hell

The Brothers were hardly alone:
on the roofs
on the walkways
in turrets
and tunnels
from windows
and whirlybirds

overhead

The State
lay in wait

Attica Attack Troops
wearing masks
carrying gas canisters
and proud to be white
proud to be doing
what everyone can
for The Man

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Attica Attack Troops
lay armed
at the ready
legalized killers
hard
chewing gum
to master an all-American impatience
to kill
to spill blood
to spill blood of the Bloods

and not one with a gun

the State
lay in wait

Attica Attack Troops
carrying pistols and
big-game / .270 rifles and
Ithaca Model 37 shotguns
with double-o buckshot
and also
shotguns appropriate
for "antivehicle duty"
or shotguns appropriate

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for "reducing a cement block wall
to rubble"
they were ready

for what?

(oh) wherever I go (these
days)
the tide seems low
Fifteen Hundred and Thirty Eight
Prisoners
lay waiting for the next
day's sun
Fifteen Hundred and Thirty Eight
Brothers
asleep
and not one with a gun
not one with a gun.

2

Why did the Brothers revolt
against Attica?

why were they there?

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What did they want?

the minimum wage
less pork
fresh fruit
religious freedom
and more than one shower a week.

What did they want?

a response
recognition
as men
"WE are MEN!" They
declared:
"WE are MEN!
We are not beasts and do not
intend to be beaten
or driven as such."

ATTICA!
ALLENDE!
AMERIKA!

The State
lay in wait.

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3

Black woman weeping at the coldstone wall
Rain stops. And blood begins to fall

"JACKPOT ONE!" was the animal
cry of The State
in its final
reply
"JACKPOT ONE!!"
was the cry

9:26 A.M.
Monday the thirteenth
September 1971
Police
State Troopers
prison guards
helicopters/The Attica Attack Troops
terrified the morning
broke through
to the beasts within them
beasts
unleashed by the Almighty
Multinational
Corporate

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Incorporeal
Bank of the World
Despoilers
of Harlem
Cambodia
Chile
Detroit
the Philippines
Oakland
Montgomery
Dallas
South Africa
Albany
Attica
Attica
The Attica Killers
The Almighty state shot/
murdered/massacred
forty three men
forty three men

The other Brothers/they
were gassed and
beaten
bleeding or not

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still clubbed and beaten:

"Nigger! You should
have got it through the head!
Nigger! You gone wish that you were
dead! Nigger! Nigger!"

Monday the Thirteenth
September 1971
Attica
Blood fell on the Brothers: Not one with a gun.
Black women weeping into coldstone.

4

wherever I go (these
days)
the tide seems low
(oh) wherever I go (these
days)
the tide seems very
very low

God's love has turned away
from this Almighty place

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But
I will pray
one prayer while He yet grants me
oime and space:

NO MORE AND NEVER AGAIN!
NO MORE AND NEVER AGAIN!

A-men.
A-men.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

Minnesota State Qualifier

NOTE: Additional background information about the Attica Riot of 1971 can be found at http://www.talkinghistory.org/attica/